The Army therefore runs its own educational institutions—the Army Public Schools (APS). Delhi has three of them; APS, Dhaula Kuan is the oldest, APS, Delhi Cantt, and APS, Shankar Vihar, the most recent. While the day-to-day functioning of the school rests with the respective principals, the overall administration of these schools also came within the purview of the Area. All the APS, not just in Delhi, are run on shoestring budgets. Since the schools are run as a welfare measure, the fee charged from the parents is the bare minimum and, as far as possible, within the CEA of Rs 2250 per child per month. The fees so collected are just about sufficient to cater for the salaries of the staff, which are also nowhere near what is given in private schools, which can charge larger fees, or government-run schools, which get grants-in-aid. Yet we are supposed to follow and implement all the relevant state and Central rules. How are we supposed to implement the 25 per cent quota for the Economically Weak Section (EWS) students when the school itself is economically weak? Or will our children have to learn a new third language, the language of the state their parent is posted to, every two years, placing them at a perennial disadvantage? These issues had to be addressed at the state level with the Delhi government and larger issues had to be taken up with the Army HQ. Many of these issues remain unresolved because, when new policies are made, the views of the Armed Forces are not sought, and once a new policy is promulgated, it takes a lot of time and effort to make any amendments.

Lt Gen PM Hariz, the Southern Army Commander, was retiring in December 2017, against which vacancy I would be promoted to the rank of Army Commander. It made logical sense for me to go to Pune and that is what the rumour mills also suggested. Imagine my surprise, therefore, when the posting

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